Some thoughts I had the other day

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Spring 2026

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Abstract

Based on a worry about the distance between architect and built fact, this essay takes on the question of what architectural practice could be, and perhaps should be. It does so by reflecting, in retrospect, on what a practitioner does and what a practice becomes, when creating a series of design proposals in and around Stockholm.

By conducting site specific studies, archival searches and a lot of work close to different physical materials, sketches became things, and things together became space, the architect became someone who crafts space rather than making projections of it. This physical manifestation of thoughts, prototypes, furniture, models, drawings, and sketches connects architectural practice to more than image making or the design of style, instead it is grounded in attention, care and the understanding of craft. It does so by intertwining reflections that have their foundation in authors such as Pier Vittorio Aureli, Aldo Rossi, Thomas Tempte, Lars Lerup, Hartmut Rosa, Mierle Laderman Ukeles, Bruno Latour and Albena Yaneva.

Recognizing itself to be a beginning, the essay ends by reading the proposed practice as one of slowness and slowing down, not in the sense of being unproductive, but rather of being aware, of paying attention and of taking time to understand what one creates and the world from which it emerges.

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Stories I wish to tell

During the last years I have been searching for a fundamental link between practice and thought. I have asked myself about the role of an architect, and by practicing, I have manufactured many answers of my own. The purpose of this essay is to provide a guide into the work that I have done as an act to search, the thoughts I have had and the conclusions I can draw out of the many days that I have spent working with my ideas, materials and hands to create imagined architectural interventions across scales and sites represented using various formats. Maybe this essay is a manifesto, written between the lines, a text about how I see the world, what I believe architectural practice is, and what I want it to be.

My need to look for different ways to practice stems from an underlying feeling of a division taking place between the practice of architecture and the built fact. A motion dissected and described by Pier Vittorio Aureli in his book Architecture and abstraction, where he writes that ”the architectural project today is fragmented into subcontracted competencies and professional roles. This fragmentation is driven not by the benefit, or use value, of cooperation among different experts, but by the exchange value driven by profit.” (2023, pp.255). A process that leads to what I fear can be seen around us, that ”this tendency reduces architects to mere providers of artistic veneer behind which lies a complex conglomerate of financial and technical mechanisms that they can no longer control” (Aureli 2023, pp.255).

I am scared that we as a workforce don’t take accountability of and claim our knowledge, but instead fall into the trap of reducing it to something that fits contemporary ideas of values and wants. A practice where our job is making a polar, either or, choice between the visually appealing, the functional or the economical. This reduction of the practice is often experienced when taking part of the long lasting, emotionally charged, debate of what new architecture should be when buildings are being developed in Sweden.

This is something I reacted to when reading the article ”Göteborgs arkitektur ritas om: ”Det pågår absolut ett paradigmskifte” [Gothenburg’s Architecture Is Being Redrawn: “A Paradigm Shift Is Definitely Underway”]” published in Dagens Nyheter. In the article a planned sub urban housing project is being brought to the public due to its radical changes mid-project. The changes were made because of new political enforcements and budgets specifically targeting chosen architectural styles, lifting some, forbidding others, and at the same time to develop properties that would be easier to sell. The article compiles statements made by different actors such as politicians, real estate developers, property managers and architects, underwhelmingly the latter try to lift other aspects than style and appearance, however unsuccessfully. Their arguments are overpowered by the previous discussions and visual comparisons made between each offices’ exterior renders (Näslund & Ljung Nielsen 2025).

The lack of specific explanations of the actual architecture scares me. That the discussion fails to speak of the ideas about the buildings where people will live their lives. Will this reduction of the practice be its silent death?

I hope to counteract this motion by letting you see my search, my not knowing, and knowing. To follow my thought, to show you my tools. I want to show to you the translation of ideas into physical matter, the processes needed to go there. Thereby I hope to fill in the gap, the whats and whys, beyond a search for beauty, provocation, solving a problem or generating something to sell. I am searching for an honesty within the profession, I believe that un-sureness is necessary for creating a better architectural practice, the one that can be explained, can develop and adapt. An architecture for human beings living between assembled materials, not solely for profit.

Therefore I want the essay to be as close to my thinking process as possible, to reflect the many stones I have turned, paths of interests I have followed and conversations I have tried to have about the endless specific details that matter to me. I want to inspire and I want to comment and I want to provoke. I want you to feel happy, frustrated and intrigued. I want you to look for answers and make up your own.

First, one has to begin

To search I have made. I have walked, I have sketched, I have built, I have discarded. I drew, I read, I wrote, I discussed. I existed in this motion where ideas and curiosities were materializing. Surrounded by machines, questions, opinions, rules, responsibilities, bushes, lawns and buildings.

Somehow this all can be condensed into one action. I thought. I thought about this and that. I thought by using my pencil, I thought by walking, I thought by feeling with my hands. I thought by reading. I thought by digging in archives. I thought by collecting. I thought by writing. I thought by setting up the router until it was perfect to the tenth of a millimeter.

I did not know that this was the beginning, but in a way it was an action, a complex set of movements and thoughts that spiralled into this motion. Miralles suggested walking to begin a creative process (Spellman 2020). Edward W. Said writes that “a beginning immediately establishes relationships with works already existing, relationships of either continuity or antagonism or some mixture of both” (1975, p. 3), mine, was an act never intended to be a beginning, instead it was a set of actions that emerged from making.

I took it as a challenge to build a replica of a stool made for and in the Ulm School of Design, founded in 1956. This beginning itself began as an image, a conversation that set off the research of scale, materials and drawings. To be able to make a good, informed, replica, I had to get to know quite a lot about the stool beyond what it looked like on a picture found online. The stool became an object that I spent time with, day in and day out, some days for hours, other days just for some minutes. I had to know what it looked like before, and how it is made today. I traced backwards and could see choices that had been made, what materials went where, and probably why they went there. The stool became an object that taught and told with its subtle containment of past decisions, past hands sketching on a paper or running over the surface of a wooden board.

This act is similar to the work of artist, craftsman, writer, thinker Thomas Tempte, who made a replica of Tutankhamun’s chair, and identifies it as a form of research rather than craft. He first states that the profession of most crafts predates academic tradition, and then writes that “one could say that I have engaged in a kind of investigative practice through this reconstruction of a chair. In making it, I was compelled to radically rethink both my methods of production and my way of thinking” (Tempte 1997, pp.52), likening the method as a form of development of thought, a research.

It was this act of doing that started the process of working with the existing world around me as objects to learn from, to dig deeper into and to get new ideas from. I likened this with finding a box in the attic, emptying it, picking out the seemingly incoherent bits and pieces that tell a story. After reading these fragments, I continue writing on that story, using my own elements, creating a new box to put in the attic, filled with a story to be read from the fragments left behind.

It ties together closely to an essay written by Lars Lerup that has stuck with me for a long time, because I feel that he puts into words how architecture should be read by its existing physical factors rather than verbally told stories. He argues that it is reading, the solving of a riddle, that is the most important part, regardless of what the multiple answers could be, and concludes by lifting that “a study of riddles and the process of their solution presents alternative ways of approaching environmental design. The nature of riddles tells us that suggestive, specific elements, set in a general framework, produce good riddles, rich in meaning to the insider” (Lerup 1975, pp.300-305).



Figure 1: Ulm stool replica
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

Three spires along Blekingegatan

Setting off with the feelings and thoughts I have carefully tried to make available to you, I once again began — I wanted to find a space within the city to work with in order to prove that almost every space has something interesting to it, something that can both make us understand the existing spaces better and also generate new ideas for spaces that can tell new stories. I looked towards the city, the seemingly endless combination of spaces situated in infinite sequential variations. Specifically, I looked for spaces that seemed odd and had subtle particularities that triggered fantasy and relations through personal riddles to solve.

When I was looking around the city my perception was profoundly influenced by my own recent study of Aldo Rossis work where I felt like there was a shared fascination for the regular architecture that surrounds us. Understanding the city as the synthesis of history, culture and time spent by humans living, seeing the stories from the past in the existing, Rossi writes

> I think of a nameless architecture of large cities, streets and residential blocks, of houses scattered in the countryside, of the urban cemetery in such a city as St Louis, of the people, living and dead, who have continued to build the city. We may look at modern cities without enthusiasm, but if we could only see with the eyes of the archaeologist Mycenae, we would find behind the facades and fragments of architecture the figures of the oldest heroes of our culture (Rossi 1984, pp.18).

The first space that I worked with was a street running east to west on Södermalm, on one end stands the grand Sofia kyrka, in the middle a small wooden church called Allhelgonakyrkan, on the other end a flat piece of grass, created as the result of a cut corner towards Ringvägen, called Tideliustäppan.

I looked briefly at the site initially, it was a cold February day, and went back to the studio to try my hopes at finding archival material of the the small church. When I got going, I accumulated not only the drawings of the church, but the facade drawings of every building running down the street towards the east. To create a model of the street I took the time to sort the original facade drawings of the buildings on it, a time consuming process of administrative work, but also the work of getting to know a place. I wanted to use only the facades facing the main street and cross street, it was a process of discovery, getting to know a place and its particular details, when later going back to the street, nothing felt the same, every building had its own particularity, often linked to some type of historical time, to think about.

I also spent time with the original drawings of Allhelgonakyrkan, thorough drawings of the construction hiding behind the outer layer, elevation drawings of the entire construction, cross sections of its spire. A lot of detail for what was supposed to be a temporary church, one could perhaps sense there was a degree of joy to the craft when making these drawings.

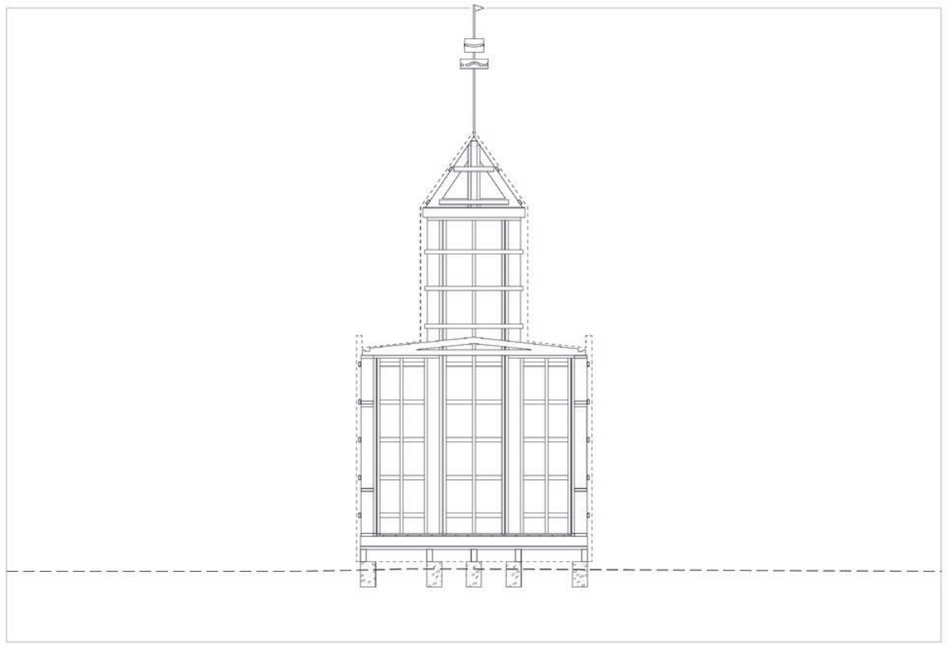
The process condensed into a proposal of a hot dog kiosk that was supposed to sit at the far end of the street, Tideliustäppan, adding another spire to the same axis of the two existing churches. I tried to capture that familiar scene that a kiosk does in the city exploring the figure and materiality of Allhelgonakyrkan. A special factor I was interested in was the the signage of a spire, I spent a lot of time drawing and constructing an aluminum mock up of one in its full scale, to capture both size but also construction methods of it, what tools were needed, what geometries meet in what ways — a translation of thoughts turned into images turned into sketches turned into built fact.



Figure 2: Full scale prototype of the spire for a hot dog kiosk
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 3: Scale model of Blekingegatan towards Ringvägen
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



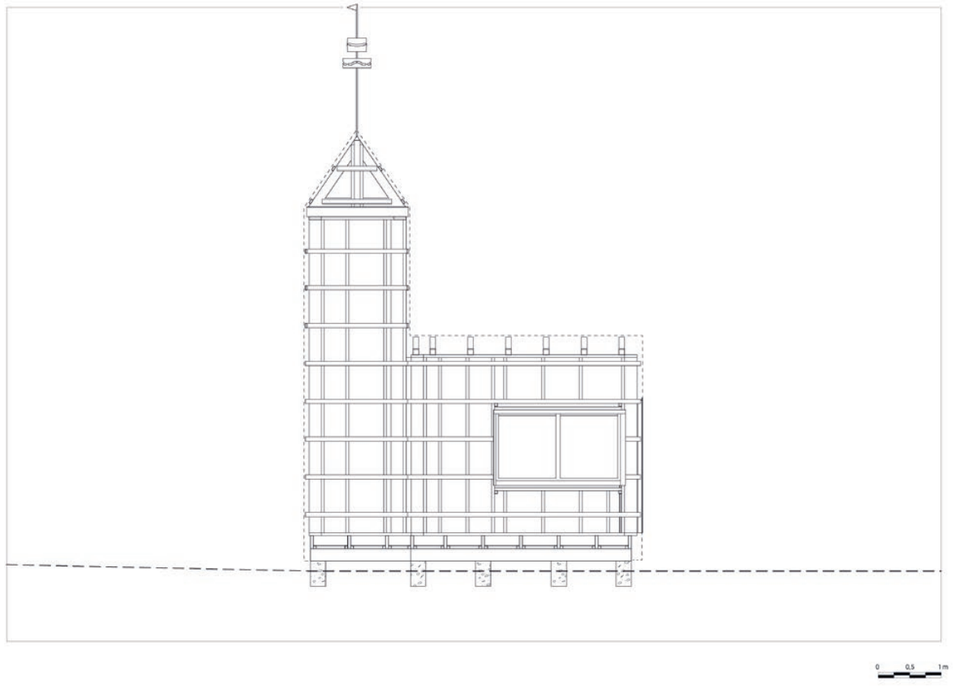
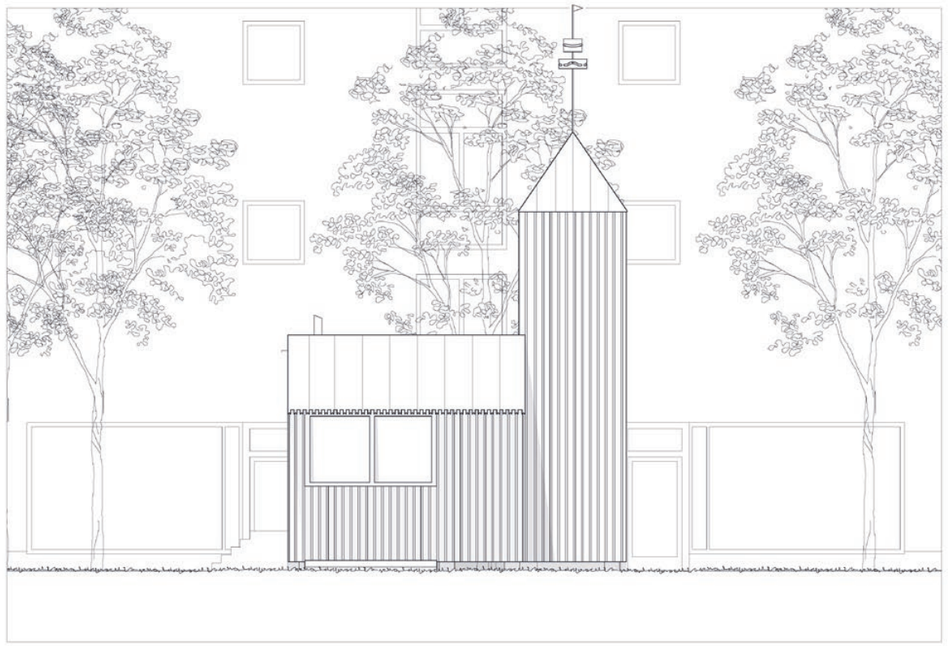


Figure 4 & 5: Drawings of structural system



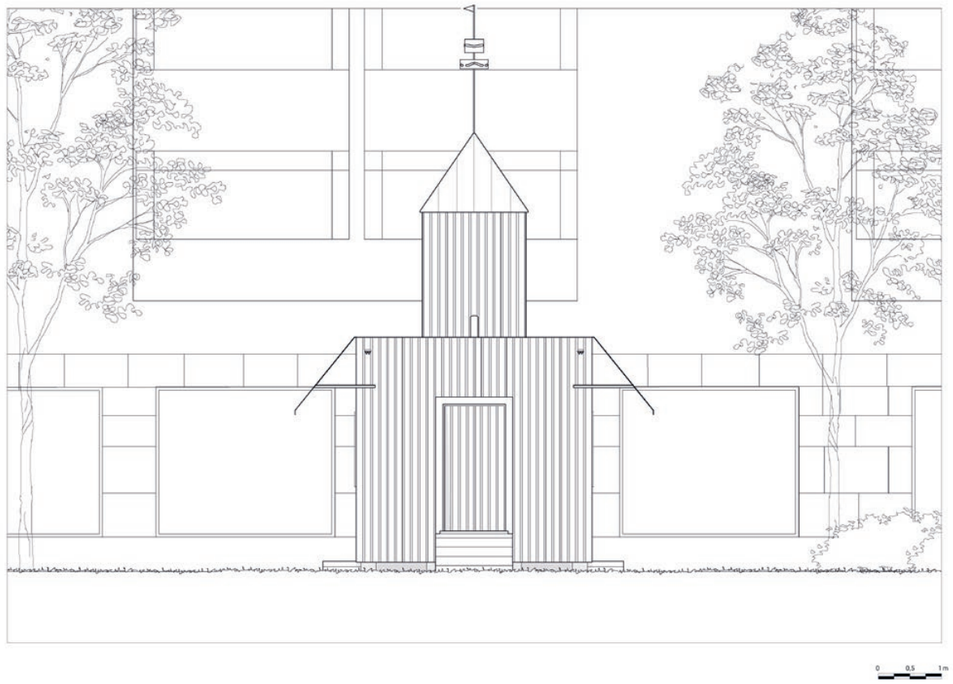


Figure 6 & 7: North and West elevations



Figure 8: Scale model of kiosk
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

An institute for warm beverages

I did not really know it at the time, but the work I did within the city embodied a type of critique against both a way of ignorantly seeing your own surroundings as empty or boring, but also against a typology of urban spaces more present now than ever, a bland mass produced space rather than a lively one. Jane Jacobs accentuates this as an important quality when she concludes her book by writing “lively, diverse, intense cities contain the seeds of their own regeneration, with energy enough to carry over for problems and needs outside themselves” (1992 pp.448).

In the following work I like to think that I worked with one of these seeds, a quirk within a space turned generic over the last years of commercialization of urban city centers.

At the heart of Stockholm, running from south to north lies Drottninggatan, a street found in so many other European cities, a street where every millimeter of space is utilized for commercial services, every now and again interrupted by a bathhouse, cultural institution and public square.

At one corner facing the gable of the huge Stockholm arts and culture centre, there lies a house with a hidden past. What one believes to be four buildings is actually one building, with four facades. Built in 1986, the building appropriates one jugend facade at its southern corner, two 19th century facades at its northern end, and replicates an iron facade of a building previously stood at the same spot.

A theatre set disguised as four buildings. Today it is home for some five or six branded stores. All within the same structural grid of columns and beams. Hidden behind the illusion of existing within a single house. Resulting in a further movement towards a fully synthetic environment. Knowing I wanted to react against this, I was looking for ways to use the spatial qualities and materials of a new proposal to stand in conversation with itself and its surroundings. I had this idea of a clash happening when something slower, something natural in its very material meets the street dominated by concrete, glass, and plastic. For this clash to work, at this site, it seemed as if I had to create a new institution to even make it believable, in contrast to the many big name brands making big changes to the spaces to sell their products, because somehow that is believable, and possible.

I ended up drawing what I call an institute for warm beverages, the proposal is to open up the spaces along the facade of the building without touching any structural elements, and make the space stretch along all four facades. Entering from one of the many, nonhierarchical entrances, you grab a chair, hang you coat and sit down for something to drink.

To tie together the spaces I created a spatial logic where layers of elements create a scenography, a system of cabinets serve as the main backdrop, chairs and tables as the main scene, when one finds a spot for sitting down, one becomes part of the everyday theatrics along Drottninggatan. However, the space is as much experienced from the inside as outside, one is to be sheltered by long rows of pine cabinets that run along the room, to interact with chairs hanging from long peg rails, and to hang the coat from shelves out of pine, when one finds a spot for sitting down, one can also watch out towards the, other, everyday theatrics on Drottninggatan.

Today it is home for some five or six branded stores, but the architecture itself holds the seeds for a future where it could be something else.



Figure 9: One entrance towards Drottninggatan from Klarahuset
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

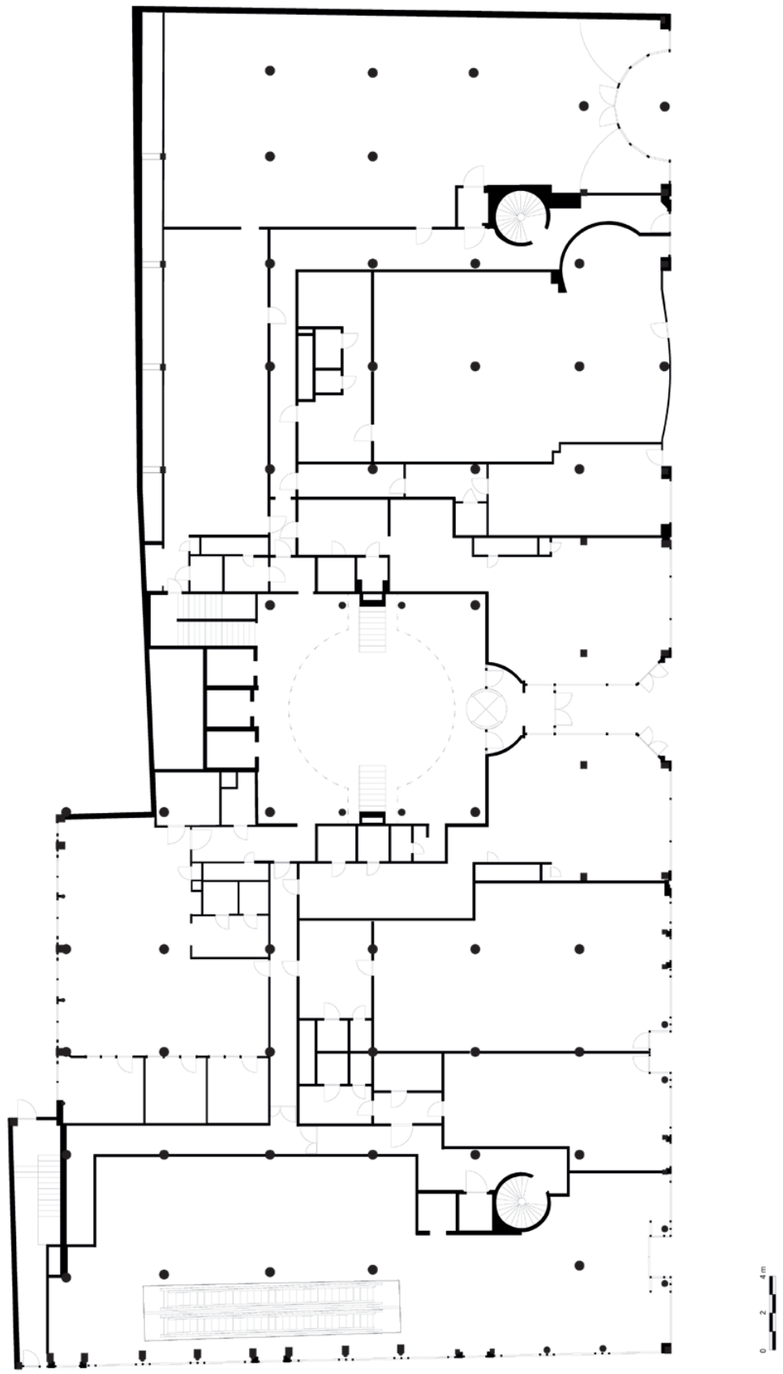


Figure 10: Plan drawing of Klarahuset

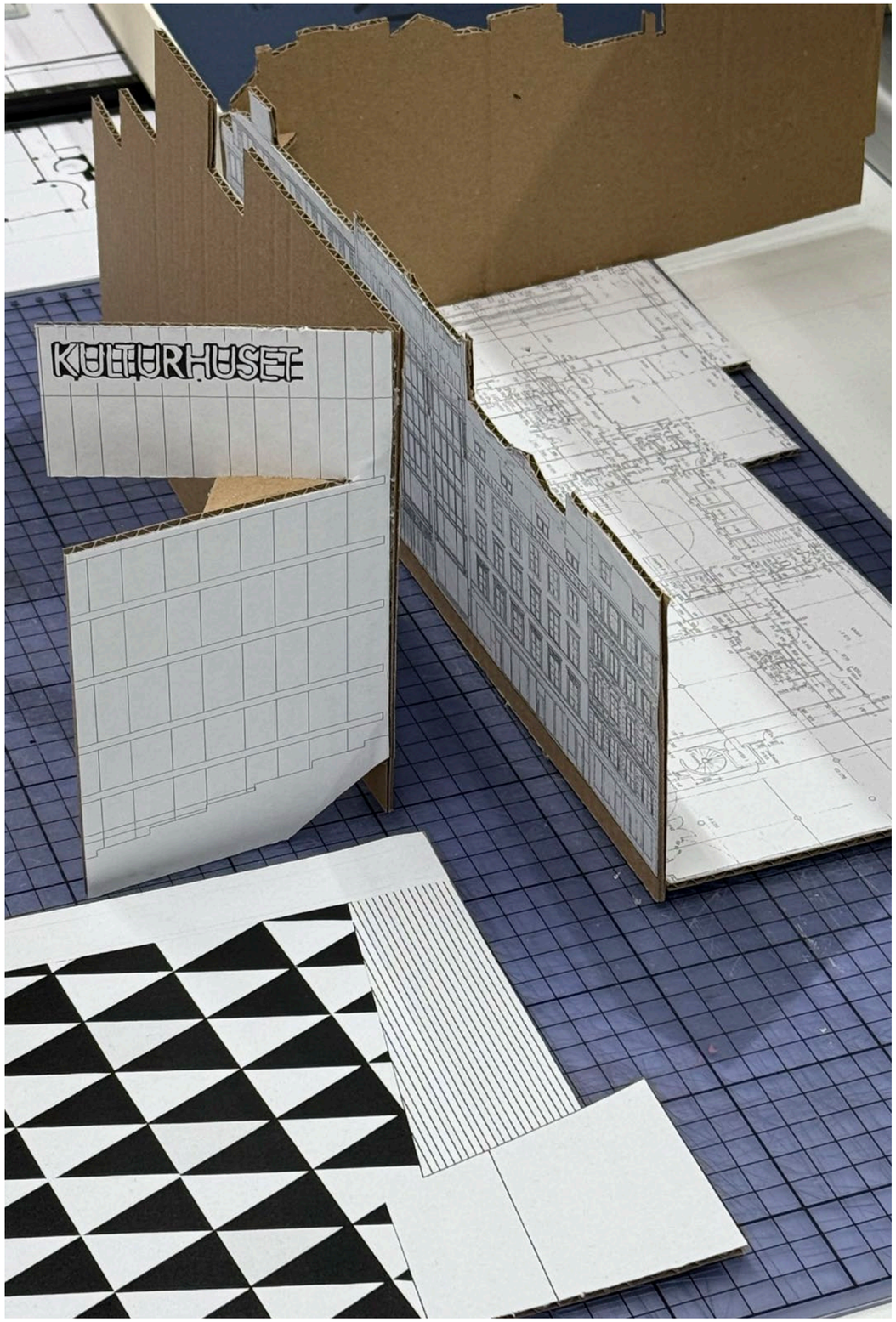


Figure 11: Model of Kulturhuset, Klarahuset and Sergels torg
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

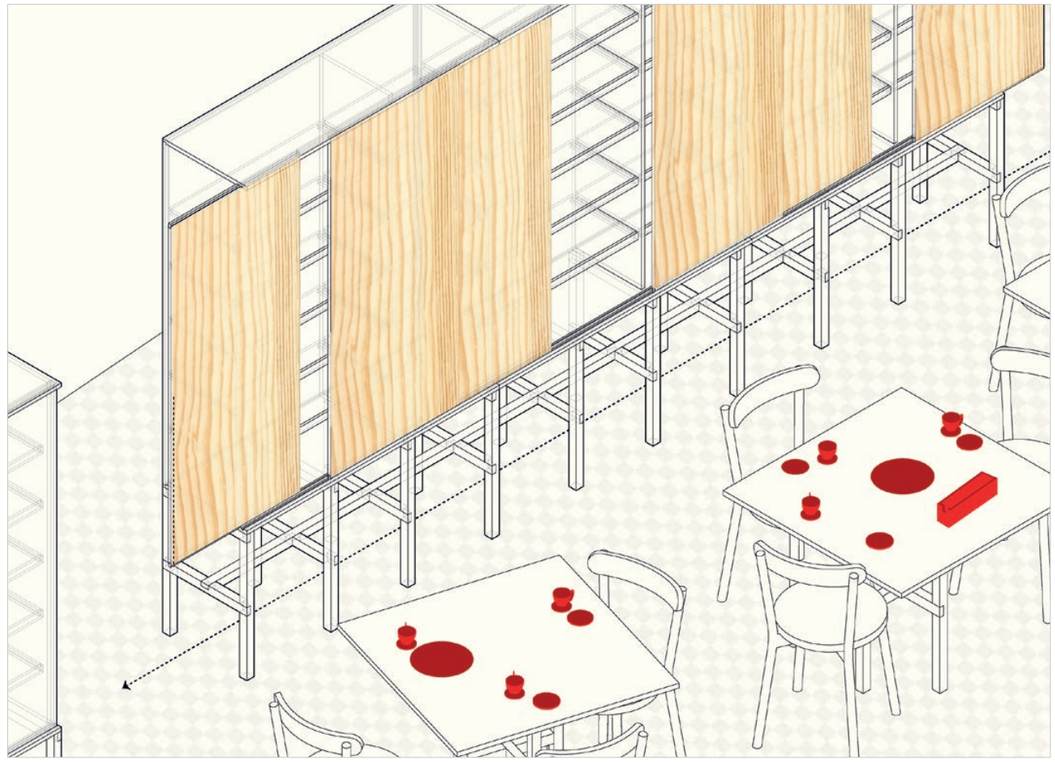


Figure 12: Principle of relation between objects at the institute for warm beverages

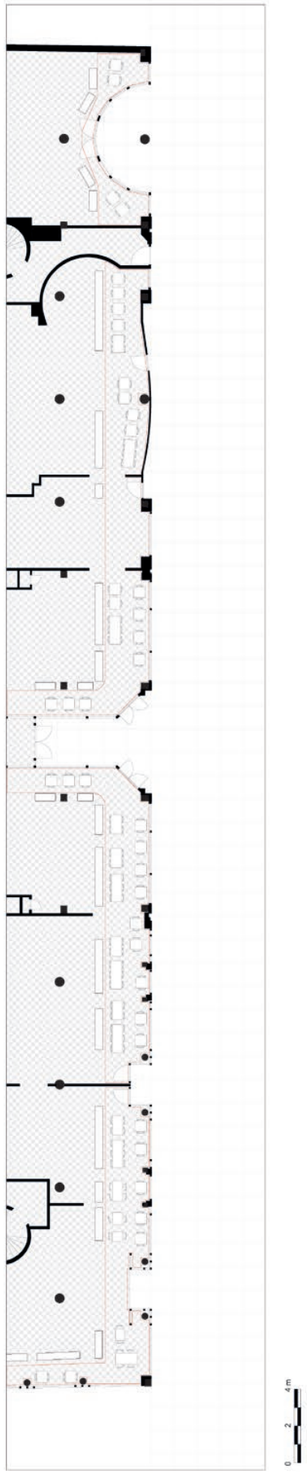


Figure 13: Plan drawing of the proposal



Figure 14: Elevation from Drottninggatan of the proposal



Figure 15: Model of a section of the proposal
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

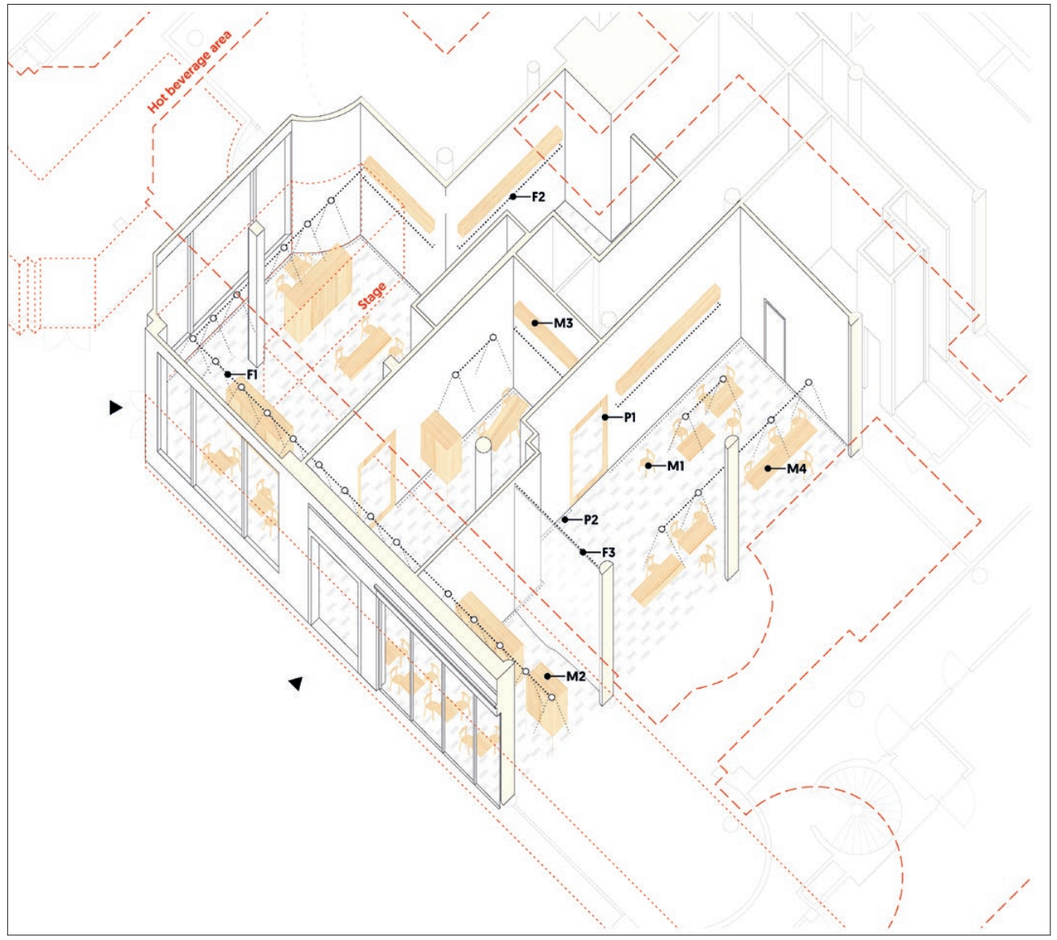


Figure 16: Fixtures, furniture and profiles needed for the proposal





Figure 17 & 18: Cabinet system with sliding doors
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 19: Chair for the institute for warm beverages
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

Greeted by flowers at Hökarängens metro station

This next chapter intertwines the previous two within a proposal that combines both thinking about everyday life scenes and the full scale materialization of ideas. It began with having an urge to get away from the computer and into the real world, getting out of scale drawings, renders, seeing and materials as images. On my way home, I ascended the stairwell from the subway platform and was greeted, as usual, by a flower store right by the side of the entrance. Usually I haven't thought about spaces like this, but as I had started getting into a mode of working with the city around me, I was constantly, happily, looking everywhere for spaces that spoke to me.

One could say that I had found a type of relationship to the world around me, a way to exist among things, a type of relationship between people and their surroundings that sociologist Hartmut Rosa calls resonance. In their introduction to an interview with Hartmut Rosa, Karl Cassegård, Karl Malmqvist and Christian Ståhl write that "the concept of resonance, which Rosa defines as a mode of relation where both subject and world are able to 'speak with their own voice' yet at the same time remain responsive or receptive to each other's voices" (2023, pp.178-179). Later Cassegård, Malmqvist and Ståhl connect the concept of resonance to a will to be connected, as they write "according to Rosa, human subjects are basically driven by a desire for resonance and a fear of alienation" (2023, pp.178-179).

A flower store at a subway station, how fantastic is that! Somewhere and somehow the space spoke back, it made me think of possible sequences of people coming home and buying flowers as the first thing when approaching home after a long day at work. But it was not only the specific program at that placement that intrigued me. It was also the ability to generalize a material urban condition and tie it to something more than functional, it inspired me to look at other metro stations around Stockholm to draw a flower store of my own.

Stockholm consists of an inner city surrounded by satellite cities. The metro allows for quick travel from the outskirts of the city into it. This network in the urban fabric has come to generate a range of spatial conditions varying from the city centre outwards. The environments created by the program of a metro station is a repeated familiar space often directed by what services are in close connection to the station.

South of the city on the first built metro line, the tracks run above ground, in between pine trees, oaks and suburban buildings, on viaducts ending in nodes at each architecturally humbled station. This is a particular condition that materializes at the historical first end station, that is, Hökarängen.

Previously the station had exposed wooden roof beams. They have now been painted over. Same goes for the red cedar benches, situated at every other steel column. The surrounding area consists to one side, the western one, of pine trees, oaks, dirt floors. Towards the Hökarängens centrum, the east, the 1950s architecture rises in between spots of trees and green islands. A combination of contrasting materiality that somehow works in harmony.

Hökarängen speaks in subtle ways, one detail that at a first glance feels ordinary are the opening of the ground level corners of some of the buildings. The otherwise hidden structure of these houses is exposed, a corner column is framed by big wooden framed windows. Fittings in polished steel ties it all together to the metro station you arrive from.

Pine trees, wood, steel, concrete and dirt.

Through the windows of a train wagon, first in the tunnels blasted deep in the bedrock beneath the city, to a slideshow with suburbia as scenery. Greeted after arrival by polished steel, pine wood and that particular smell that exists in a flower store selling fresh flowers.



Figure 20: Hökarängens metro platform facing south
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 21: Hökarängens metro station, 1957, Unknown Photographer
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Figure 22: Hökarängens metro station north entrance
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

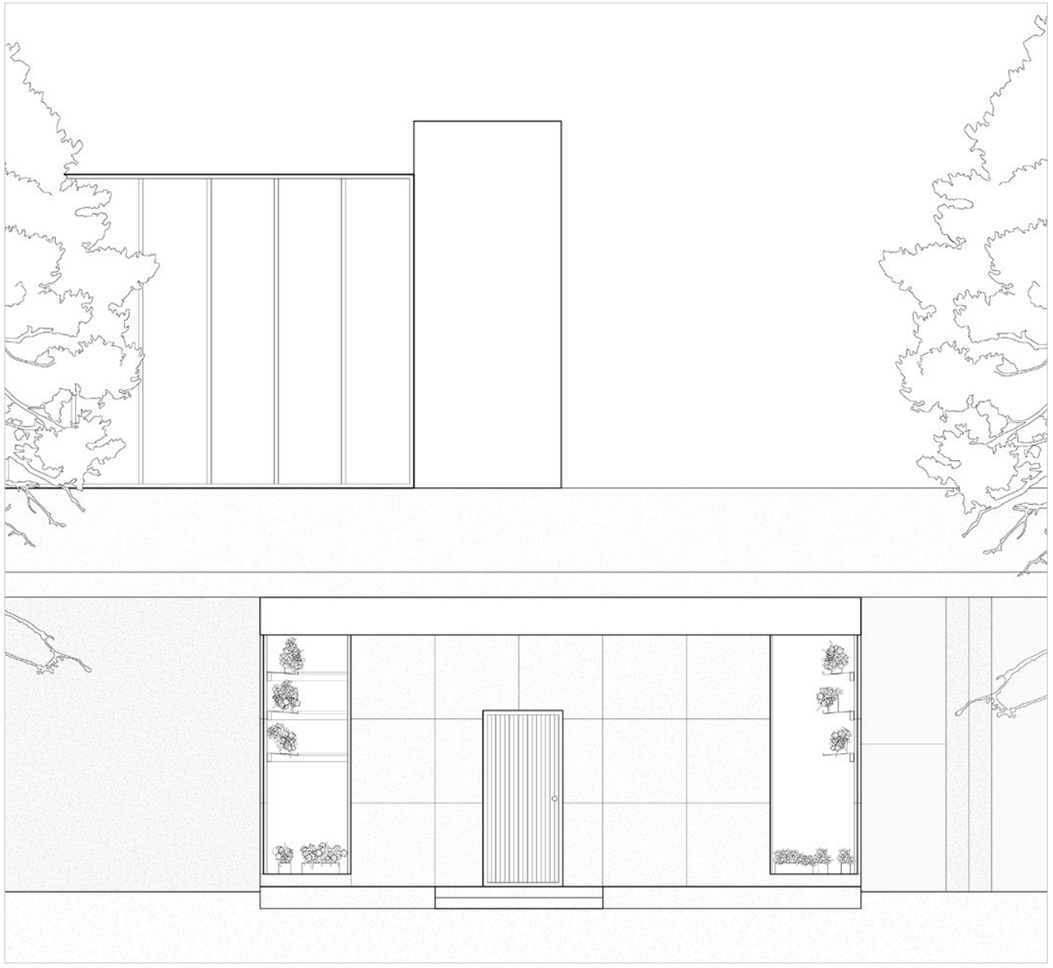


Figure 23: Flower store east elevation

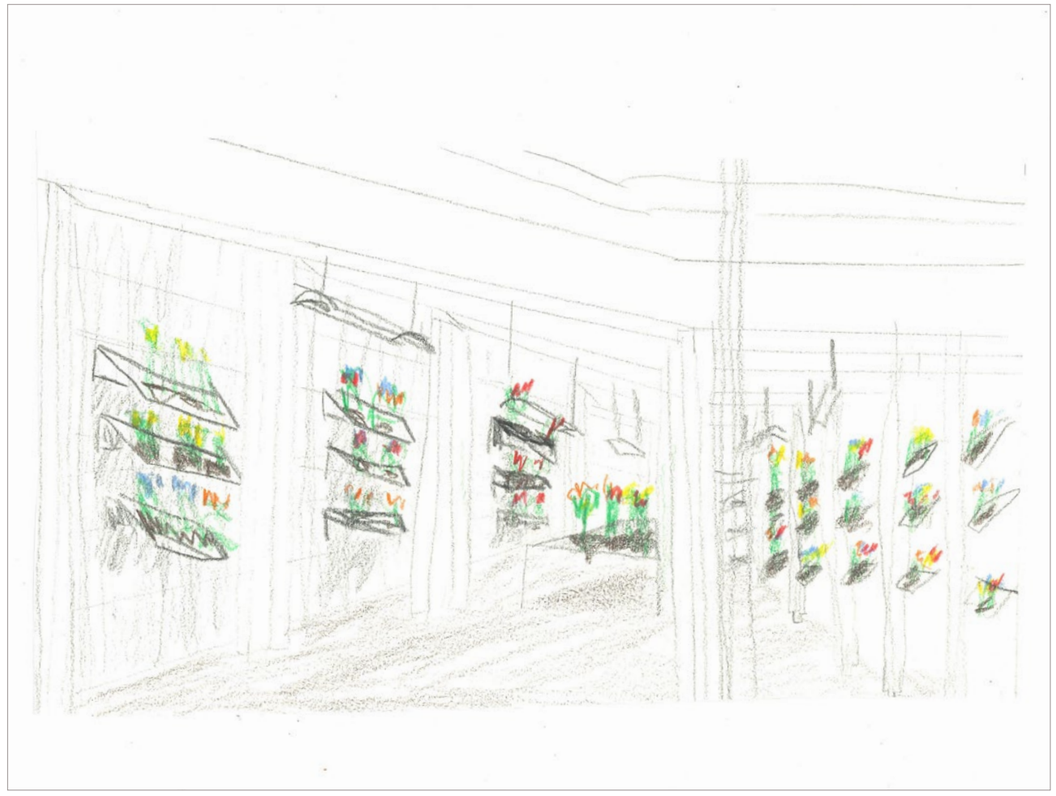


Figure 24: Sketch of flower store interior

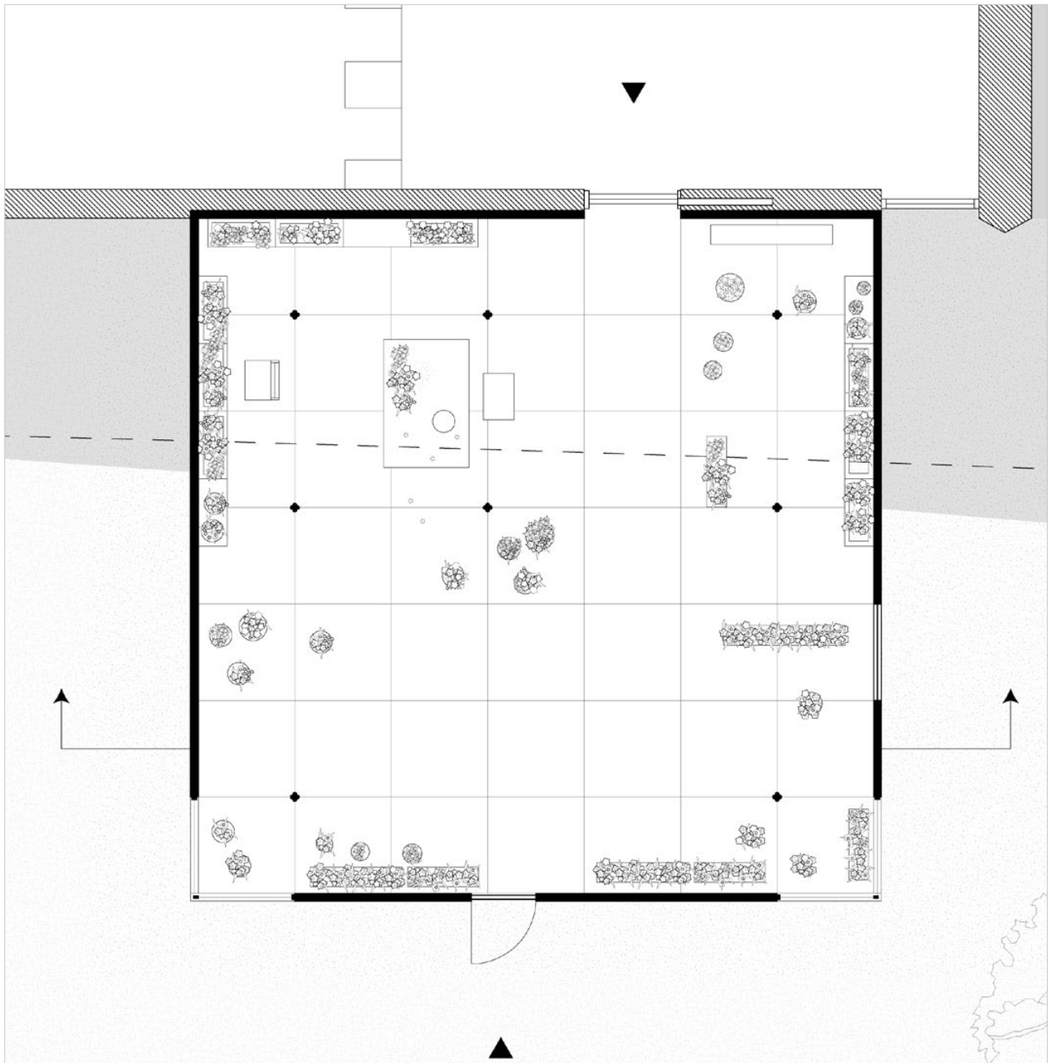


Figure 25: Plan drawing of flower store

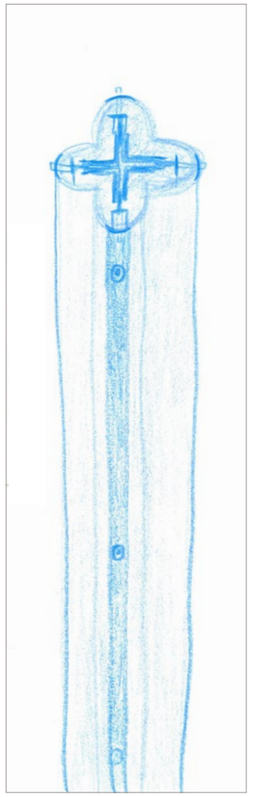


Figure 26: Pillar sketch



Figure 27: Mock-up of pillar in full scale
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 28: Section of pillar in full scale
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 29: Lamp for a flower store
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

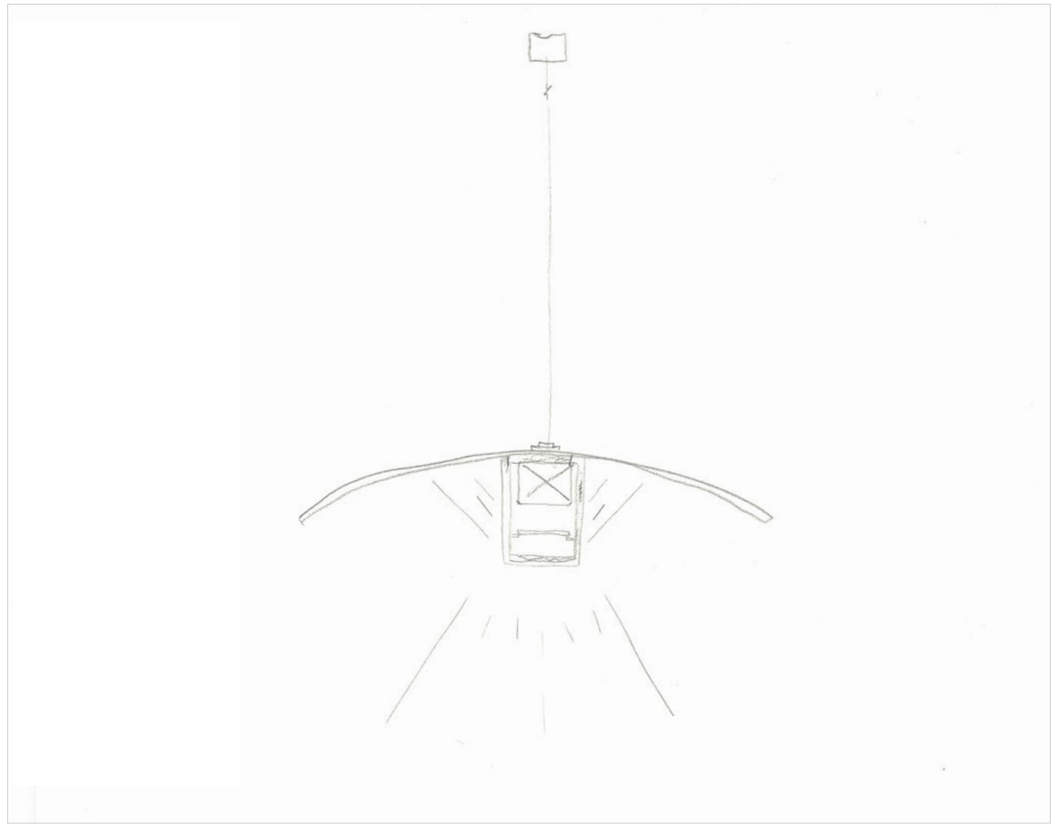


Figure 30: Sketch of lamp for a flower store
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch





Figure 31 & 32: Section model of a flower store
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 33: Section model of flower store interior
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 34: Model of flower store interior
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

In my development of this space I wanted to cite the existing, or the painted over existing, I wanted to show what had spoken to me when wandering about. I used the footprint of a kiosk, with wood cabin sidings painted in a strong cyan blue color, as a starting point for the addition of a flower store instead.

From there I tried to find a language from the existing, I created a spatial order beginning from open corners and steel columns that meet cross laminated timber beams. I took these materialities and translated them into objects for the store, a pine step ladder to reach polished steel shelves held up by pine moldings and a lamp with the same material combination. I spent a lot of my time developing a version of Mies Van Der Rohes famous pillar seen in Villa Tugendhat and the Barcelona pavilion, a pillar made out of standard steel profiles and encased with a polished shell. This translation from picture, sketch and material is in many ways what makes the space possible, and the execution of a full scale prototype gives me as an author control of that detail, that otherwise would stay a sketch, a 3d model or placeholder pillar. The pillar could then be placed in scale into drawings and a cardboard model, to try to work out where the pillars could stand and what outcome of spatial experience this would provide.

A text resurfaced to me when dwelling on this topic, by Albena Yaneva and Bruno Latour, who in their essay Give Me a Gun and I Will Make All Buildings Move: An Ant's View of Architecture wrote:

> Drawing and modelling do not constitute an immediate means of translating the internal energies and fantasies of the architect's mind's eye, nor a process of transferring ideas from the designer's mind into physical form. Rather, the hundreds of models and drawings produced in design form an artistically created primal matter that stimulates the haptic imagination, astonishes its creators instead of obeying them, and helps architects fix unfamiliar ideas, gain new knowledge about the building-to-come, and formulate new alternatives and 'options,' new unforeseen scenarios of realisation (Yaneva & Latour 2017, pp.84).

An entrance, stairwell and facade to begin

This last part is about a plot where a proposal already existed. I saw this as an opportunity to give an alternative approach on how to develop future plans of an area where there was an actual ongoing discussion of development, that had been paused because of complaints.

The plot is situated behind Midsommargården, a yellow brick building facing a square with a small fountain and some benches. It was drawn by the same architect who was responsible for the old telephone factory that gave this part of the city its current name.

In contrast with most other buildings here, it is playful in its details. It has large wooden fixtures, window frames and doors. It has many different openings, window bays and balconies. The residential area behind it consists mainly of narrow buildings lacking these playful elements. But containing other, more subtle material choices and placements. But the main aspect that I thought one should work with was their gardens, gardens that span along the entire streets, reaching up to the skirting of the houses, instead of having a broad paved way up to the entrance, there are small paths surrounded by grass. The open areas mostly used for catching the spring sun, letting the kids play, or walking the dog, they capture a greater sense of the surroundings than the buildings themselves.

It was this feeling I wanted to capture with my proposal. Instead of a volumetric representation, what the city had published online as an image for the proposed new buildings, I started with a door handle. Then the door, and lastly chairs for the morning sun and a table for two cups of coffee. I noticed the surrounding buildings had their entrances accentuated by surrounding tiles, white, green, dark blue, a careful attention that I implemented in the design of the proposed facade.

The result might not have been a complete project or solution, but it was a beginning, and a transparent idea where I could communicate my choices, in comparison to the rendered images seen online, and if I look back to my first reaction towards the article where houses had been compared for their visual renders and the focus of aesthetics rather than other qualities, I realize that this proposal focuses on the opposite. A door handle out of elm wood is not the solution to any housing problem or urban development, however it is also not a big cost, to allow such a design to be implemented within spaces, to give them qualities that people knowingly or unknowingly will feel in their hand every day.



Figure 35: Telefonplans metro station, 1957, Unknown Photographer
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Behind the station lies Midsommargården, and the proposed site



Figure 36: Proposed site behind Midsommargården
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 37: Sketch of an entrance and outdoor area



Figure 38: Sketch of a chair

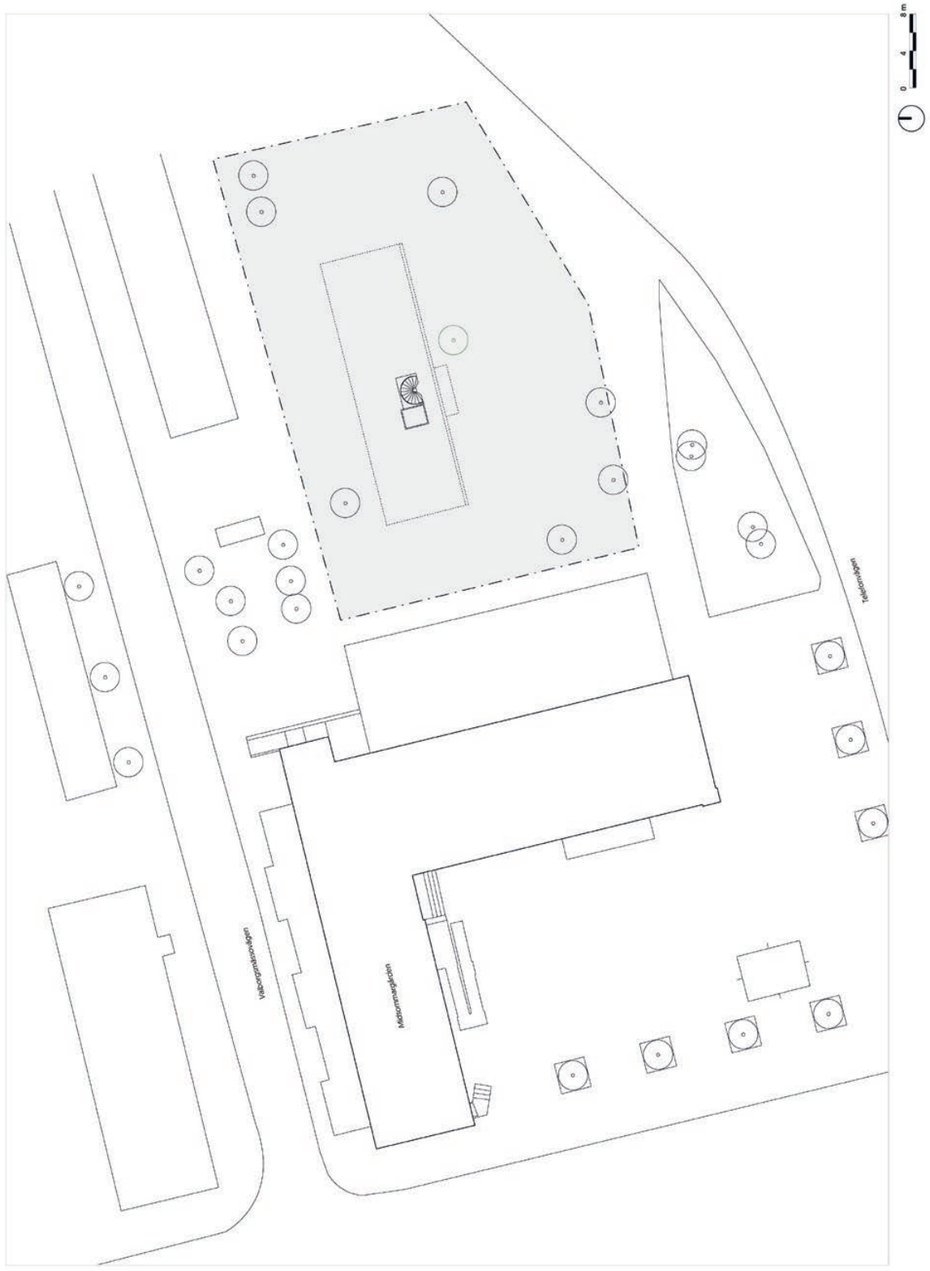


Figure 39: Site plan



Figure 40: Isometric drawing of facade, staircase and entrance



Figure 41: Chair for the morning sun
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 42: Table for two cups of coffe
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

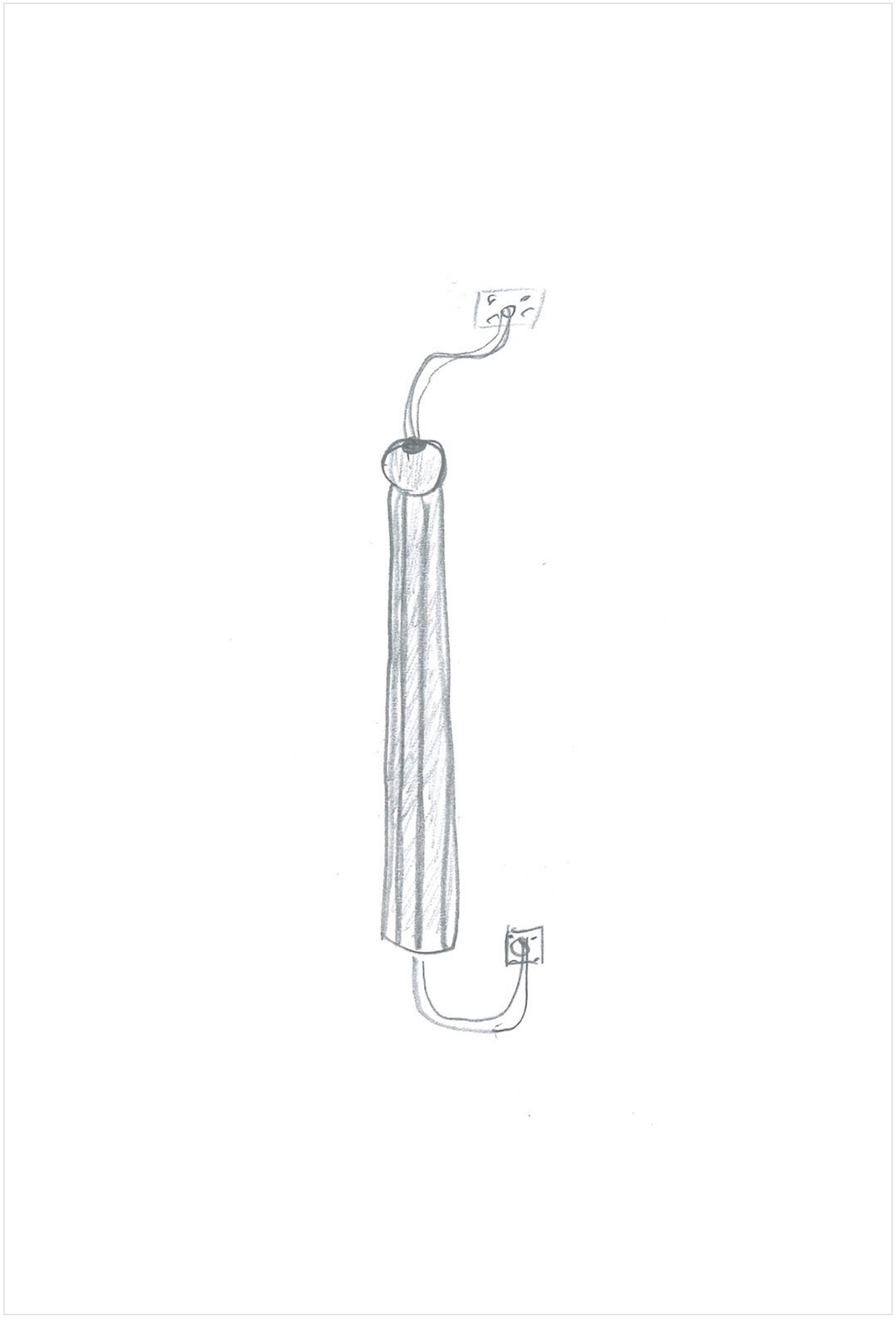


Figure 43: Sketch of doorhandle



Figure 44: Sketch of a table for two cups of coffe



Figure 45: South elevation of proposed facade



Figure 46: Mock up door & prototype of doorhandle
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch



Figure 47: Two chairs for the morning sun, one table for two cups of coffe
Photo: Valentin Strohkirch

The practice today, maybe tomorrow

In the end the development of this practice has covered vast ground and the beginning is starting to come to an end, or a middle, or another start. The search for the practice spans so many topics it is hard to keep track of, but in the end it is also all of these topics, thoughts and materials that matter when something, somewhere, comes into existence, often in the everyday lives of others.

In the course of my search, I have cemented my view of architectural practice like this as a profession of making things come into existence, one of translating thoughts into being, creating spaces for people to exist. The architect as author, as craftsperson.

The effect of having gone further than I have ever gone before, to develop and control details of designs, I have come closer to the built fact than ever before and that has put me in situations where I have had to make many decisions and pick a side, a process that led me to to adapt principles that I have followed and weaved into my own practice and philosophy.

In her proposal for an exhibition, and later in the exhibition itself, Mierle Laderman Ukeles unveils the illusion of the modern museum institution as an impartial actor and a blank canvas inclusive of all. She does this by proposing that her work of art will be the act of maintenance, showing the work needed to be done by somebody, to uphold the illusion of a space for everybody. The worker who cleans the space, is however not recognized, as most people who do the maintenance of the world, are put to to work behind closed doors, the maintenance is not to be seen, and if so, it is no skill or knowledge in comparison to the thing that is maintained (Laderman Ukele 1969). In her proposal Ukeles compares development and maintenance:

> Development: pure individual creation; the new; change; progress, advance, excitement, flight or fleeing.
>
> Maintenance: keep the dust off the pure individual creation; preserve the new; sustain the change; protect progress; defend and prolong the advance; renew the excitement; repeat the flight (Laderman Ukeles 1969).

I found my practice as an architect has certain similarities with the practice of maintenance, of creating spaces that stem from and maintain the existing, architecture that cares about the ones living around and in it, rather than providing a certain image or following the trends of a style needing to be maintained. To do this, I have looked towards an architecture of a chair that looks like a chair and works like a chair. Once you use it, once it helps you to sit, you do not look at it, in the end, its value is within the support it gives so that you can sit. When Donald Judd reflects on his own practice and failure of making furniture too close to his art, he captures a thought that constantly triggers big alarm signals in my head. He writes that “the art of a chair is not its resemblance to art, but is partly its reasonableness, usefulness, and scale as a chair” (1993). Far too often you can tell that design derives from solely the visual image of what something could look like, here it takes knowledge and skills to be able to create design that can be precisely manufactured, well made, and therefore useful, rather than in need of being maintained.

Judd later gives reassurance to what I believe to be closer to the role of the architect than being a designer of art, when comparing the complex and complicated, he hits the nail on the head:

> ‘Complicated,’ incidentally, is the opposite of ‘simple,’ not ‘complex,’ which both maybe. But the difference between art and architecture is fundamental. Furniture and architecture can only be approached as such. Art cannot be imposed upon them. If their nature is seriously considered the art will occur, even art close to art itself (Judd 1993).

When translating these principles to works regarding specific sites, unsurprisingly, the same aspects of readability and humbleness towards the sites seems to be a foundation for success. After showing examples of artists disregarding site conditions and locality in various degrees, Miwon Kwon states that “many critics, artists, and sponsors agreed that, at best, public art was a pleasant visual contrast to the rationalized regularity of its surroundings, providing a nice decorative effect. At worst, it was an empty trophy commemorating the powers and riches of the dominant class —a corporate bauble or architectural jewelry” (Kwon 2004, pp. 65). This fact solidifies and gives backbone to the previous principles of the chair that looks like a chair and works like a chair, the architecture that avoids being art, becomes accessible and less of a category of decoration for urban space.

To be able to create this type of architecture, I argue that we need to become better authors, craftspeople and archeologists. With a humble mindset we have to watch the world around us, and tie together aspects that can be used to generate site specific design, readable and tellable by the everyday person.

Slowing down

At the end of the beginning I am still searching, a search that has led me to develop a practice of my own, a practice of architecture that seems to belong, that I can speak about for hours and that I eagerly can dive even deeper into. I have developed a joy for the potential of the craft and I have formulated design principles that I probably will think differently about in a short while.

In the aftermath of this process I have had to conclude it, a sort of review of my beginning, a foreshadowing of the future? Looking back at the work, I realize that a consistently existing thought throughout this process has been the time needed versus the time given to complete a job. I have always found it fascinating that the effect of our work lasts for much, much longer than the time spent working on it. It is a scary thought, especially when the world seems to be accelerating to a point where nothing matters beyond the capital gain that aesthetics can provide. In retrospect, one could say that the processes that led to the designs brought up in this essay were slow, not in the sense of being unproductive or taking an abundance of time, but because they required attention, care and time spent, getting to know a place, an object or an idea. Unfinished and open-ended, they are thoughts in the making, architecture gradually becoming. I am going to claim that the relationship between quality of space and site specificity probably relates to the time spent working on it and working with it.

I long for the days where I can work on and on and on with the same space and site for a very long time. Last fall I declared this to be infinity work, the type of work that has no end, but rather cycles of action and reaction, such as working in and maintaining a garden, or the raking of rocks at Japanese rock gardens. I speculated that this, slow in the sense of never ending, work would make us more connected to what we have at hand. The same thought could be applied to what we create, that slowness and infinity work could bring a sense of understanding to the reality of our powers that alter matter seemingly infinitely.

I imagine working on the proposals that I have made for a long time, of developing them in sequences of varying speed, lasting the lifetime of the proposals. Would I enjoy it? What would be needed of a practice that works with architecture as a gardener with a garden? In general, the practice I have developed needs phases of deceleration, to be able to enjoy the pencil marks that construction workers sometimes leave behind when building a wall.

These changes of pace gives time for maintenance, for observations and for the further development of existing ideas. Slowing down gives time for enjoyment, for being thoughtful and of being close to materials and spaces.

Ironically, if I had time, I would go on about the differences between slowing down and being unproductive, of slowing down by making more, but at the benefit of this work, I will leave you with tangled thoughts and riddles that will spend time in my, and probably your heads, in order for the thought, to someday provide a legible, maybe, tangible outcome.

Illustrations

Figure 1-20
Valentin Strohkirch

Figure 21
”Hökarängens Tunnelbanestation”, 1957, Unknown Photographer
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Figure 22-34
Valentin Strohkirch

Figure 35
”Tunnelbanestationen Telefonplan”, 1964, Unknown Photographer
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Figure 36-47
Valentin Strohkirch

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